Marketing Strategy & Audience Insights Work Sample

Cygnus VEGA - AI-Infused Marketing Intelligence System

AI-Infused
Marketing Intelligence

Selected Duke Fuqua team consulting project prepared as a recruiting work sample. Focus: ICP validation, target account segmentation, buyer mapping, funnel benchmarking, ARR forecasting, KPI tracking, and GTM roadmap.

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Project Snapshot & Selected Contributions

Business Question

How should VEGA validate and refine its ideal customer profile, focus sales effort on high-fit institutions, and create a repeatable SaaS go-to-market motion?

Deliverable

A client-facing strategy deck covering target segmentation, channel insights, funnel benchmarks, ARR scenarios, KPIs, and roadmap.

Contribution Highlights

- Market and account research: filtered U.S. higher-education institutions using enrollment scale, program mix, digital maturity, and estimated marketing budget.
- Buyer and channel analysis: mapped decision-maker roles and identified high-signal associations, events, and media outlets for target outreach.
- Go-to-market recommendations: supported ICP tiering, funnel risk identification, ARR scenario modeling, KPI ownership, and a phased 180-day execution roadmap.
- Client communication: participated in the final client presentation and connected analysis to practical next steps for sales focus and scalable growth.

Note: This excerpt removes the original team-introduction page and is shortened for recruiting review.

Executive Summary

- **Objective:**
  Determine how VEGA should validate and refine its ICP to improve win rates and support scalable SaaS growth.
- **Key Insight:**
  VEGA's current ICP is directionally sound but insufficiently validated. Broad targeting dilutes sales effort, while digitally mature, high-fit institutions drive faster adoption and higher conversion.
- **What We Found:**
  - Tier 1–2 institutions and systems account for disproportionate revenue potential.
  - Digital maturity is a stronger predictor of success than institution type alone.
  - Buying decisions are consensus-driven, requiring early engagement beyond Marketing.
  - Expansion within high-fit accounts outperforms adding low-fit volume.
- **Recommendation:**
  VEGA should focus its go-to-market efforts on a validated, high-fit ICP by operationalizing tiered targeting and embedding digital maturity and buying complexity into qualification.
- **Impact:**
  Improved win rates, faster deal progression, and more predictable ARR through a focused, repeatable SaaS sales motion.

Selected work sample excerpt - Cygnus VEGA

Concentrating Sales on High-Fit Institutions Will Increase Conversion, Shorten Sales Cycles, and Improve ARR Predictability

STRATEGIC PILLARS

01

Focus Sales Effort on Accounts Most Likely to Buy

Validating VEGA's ICP narrows the funnel to institutions with the scale, digital maturity, and budget required to adopt a SaaS intelligence platform, reducing wasted sales effort and improving conversion rates.

02

Build Tiered Target List

Develop a Tier 1–3 structure based on objective data points (enrollment size, tech stack, budget). Direct proactive outbound efforts solely to Tier 1, while nurturing Tier 2 and 3 through automated channels.

03

Reduce Late-Stage Deal Friction

Embedding buying complexity and stakeholder requirements into the ICP minimizes late-stage blockers related to IT, compliance, and governance, increasing the likelihood of successful deal closure.

04

Enable Predictable and Scalable SaaS Execution

A clearly defined ICP creates a consistent target universe that supports repeatable go-to-market execution, reliable funnel modeling, and more predictable ARR forecasting.

Objective Criteria Reveal a Clear “SaaS-Ready” Segment with Scale, Martech Integration, and $500K+ Marketing Budgets

Moving beyond "any university" to "SaaS-ready institutions" ensures sales efforts target the right buyers.

ASSESSMENT CRITERIA	PRIORITY FOCUS **Ideal Profile** High Urgency & Value	**Acceptable** Nurture / Opportunistic	**Low-Fit** Deprioritize
Enrollment Scale	>5,000 Online/Grad 4 year institutions	1,500 – 5,000 Total Growing online programs; 4 year institution	<1,500 Total institutions’ program that less than 4 year
Program Focus	Online / Adult / Grad Online Program>=70%	Hybrid / Regional Mix of traditional undergrad and professional programs.	Traditional UG No online program
Martech Stack	Integrated Ecosystem Salesforce, Slate, HubSpot. Data flows but lacks "last mile" insight.	Siloed Systems Slate or CRM exists but isn't connected to ad platforms.	Legacy / Manual Banner/ERP only; reliance on Excel or external agencies.
Marketing Budget	Est Marketing Budget >=500k	Sufficient budget but less than 500k	Little to none marketing budget..

Source: https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1WNHCyeHzSiWVDKzt-1esiztaCs6BJw7esdRPS06IQTY/edit?gid=0#gid=0

Selected work sample excerpt - Duque VEGA

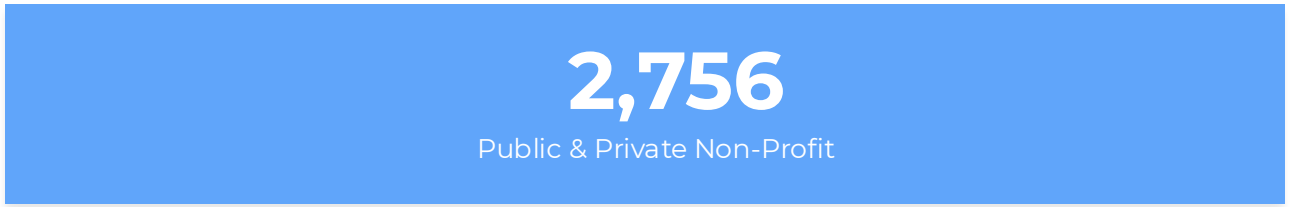
Applying VEGA's ICP to U.S. higher education yields a qualified universe of ~300 institutions

Starting with IPEDS data, we filter for size, program mix, and digital footprint to reach a serviceable market.



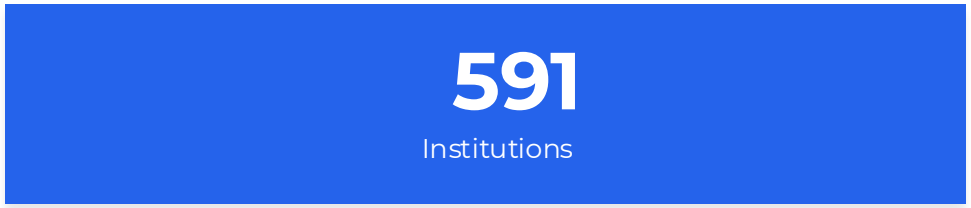
TOTAL UNIVERSE
U.S. Title IV Institutions

EXCLUSION FILTERS
- Removes <4yr



ADDRESSABLE MARKET
4-Year Degree Granting

ICP FIT FILTERS
- Removes non-profit institutions
- Removes online program% <=70



SERVICEABLE MARKET
Mid-to-Large w/ Online

READINESS FILTERS
- Est. Marketing Budget >$500k



QUALIFIED UNIVERSE
"Sales Ready"

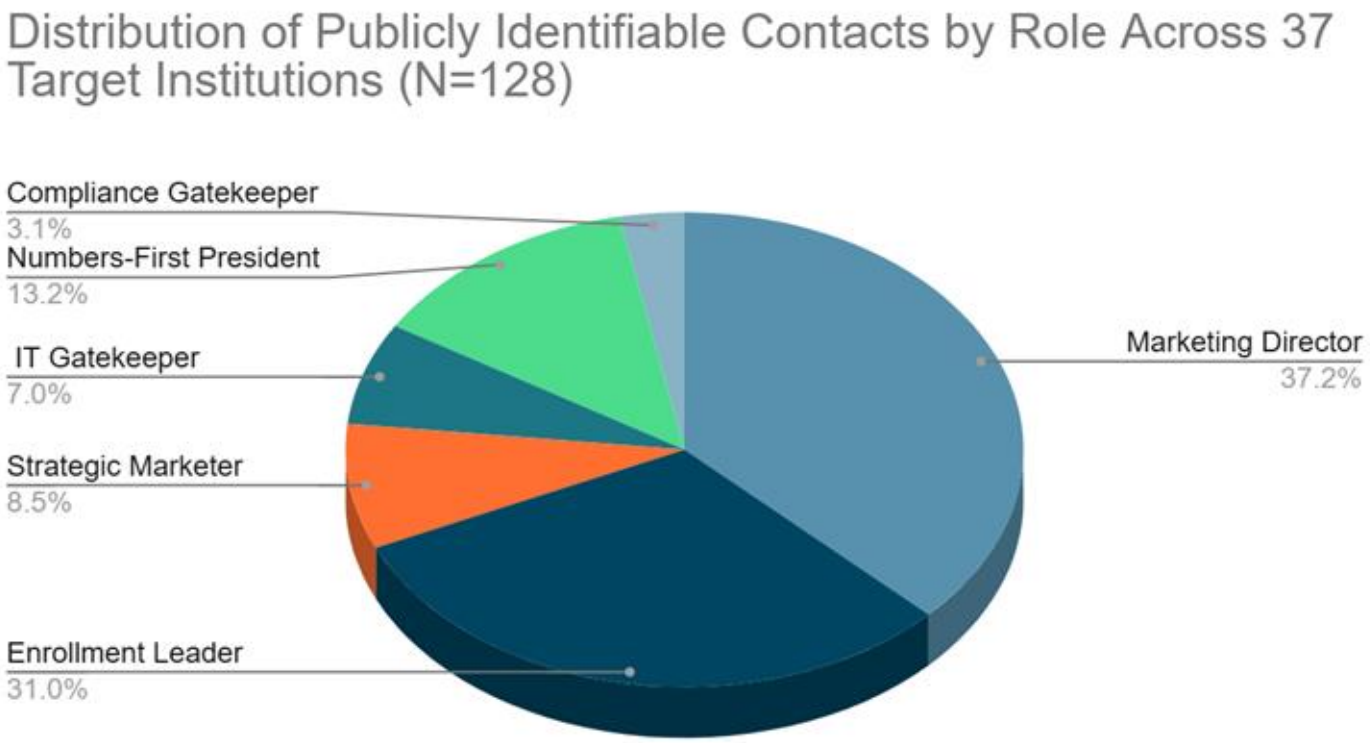
- What VEGA expected

SOURCE: https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1WNHCyeHzSiWVDKzt-1esiztaCs6BJw7esdRPS06IQTY/edit?gid=0#gid=0

Selected work sample excerpt - Cygnus VEGA

Marketing and Enrollment Roles Represent 68% of Identifiable Contacts and Should Serve as VEGA's Primary GTM Entry Point

Sample: 37 institutions; up to 5 contacts per institution （N = 128).
Method: role classification based on title + org context (LinkedIn / institution sites).



Key Insight

Marketing (37%) and Enrollment (31%) represent 68% of identifiable contacts.

Implication

Their high cross-institution visibility makes them the most scalable and repeatable starting point.

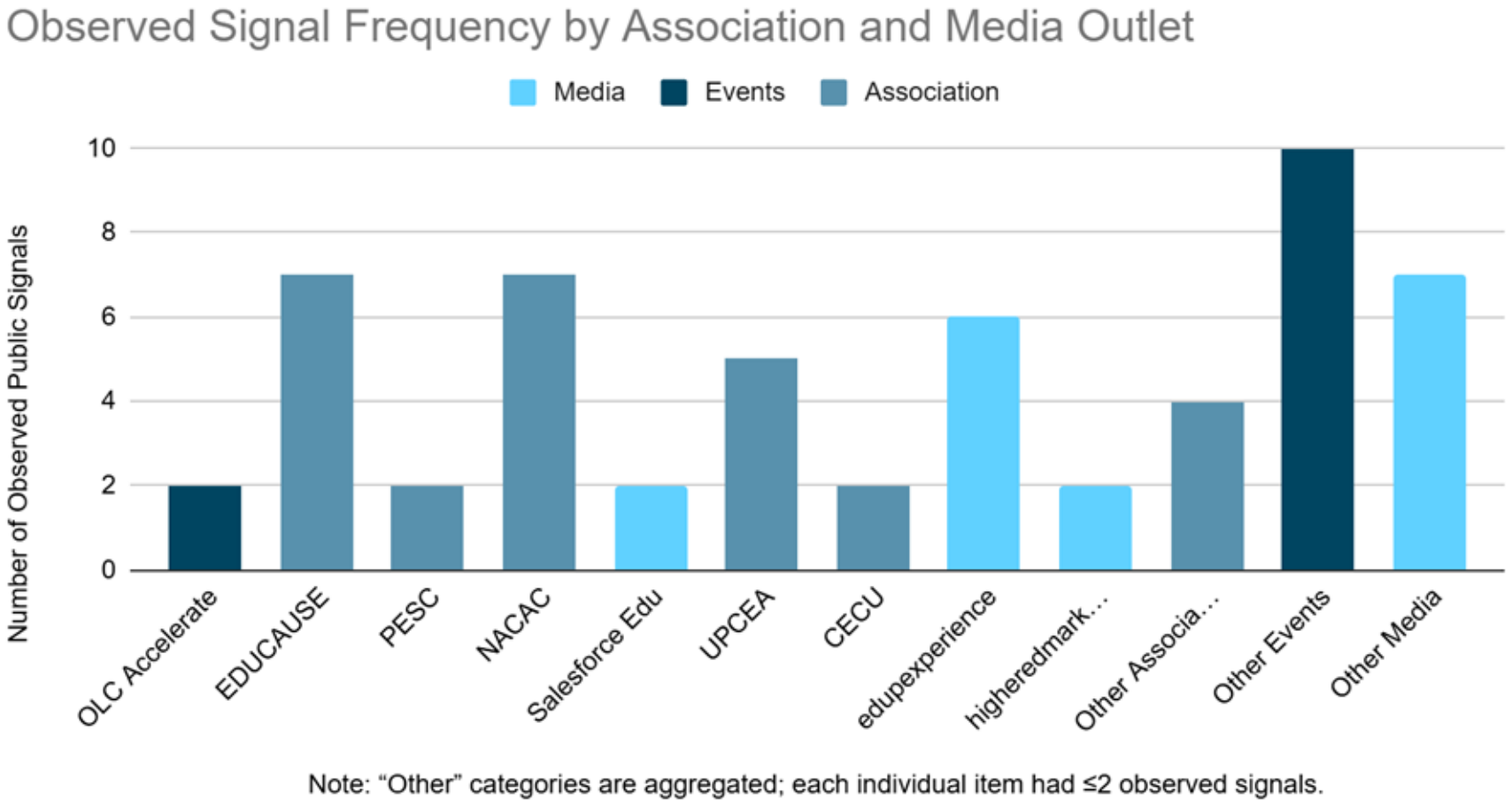
Action

Start → Marketing & Enrollment
Expand → IT
Finalize → Executive & Compliance

Notes: Percentages reflect the role distribution of publicly identifiable contacts in our sample (37 institutions; ≤5 contacts each). Results may vary by institution type and organizational structure.
SOURCE：https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1JI3SGMbUuY98Kqu6sfkSftE1OfYUHq0g/edit?usp=sharing&ouid=112460400651076501343&rtpof=true&sd=true

A Few Associations and Media Outlets Show the Strongest Signals for Reaching These Target Roles

Method: select institutions with high Meta ad activity（>90） → extract attended events / associations / media signals from public sources.



Note: “Other” categories are aggregated; each individual item had ≤2 observed signals.

- Priority 1 (high signal). EDUCAUSE + UPCEA + NACAC +edup experience
- Priority 2 (targeted): OLC Accelerate (online learning leaders)
- Focus outreach and sponsorship around the highest-signal named channels.

SOURCE: https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1JI3SGMbUuY98Kqu6sfkSftE1OfYUHq0g/edit?usp=sharing&ouid=112460400651076501343&rtpof=true&sd=true

Vega's conversion assumptions broadly align with SaaS benchmarks, but risk is concentrated in the MQL-to-SQL handoff and Opportunity-to-Closed-Won stages.

Comparison of Vega's Conversion Assumptions vs. B2B SaaS Benchmarks

Funnel Stage	Industry Benchmark	Vega Assumption	Interpretation
1. Lead → MQL	20-30%	~25%	**Aligned** - ICP definition supports expected conversion
2. MQL → SQL	20-30%	25-35%	**At risk** - Lack of standardized scoring at handoff
3. SQL → Opportunity	25-35%	~30%	**Aligned** - Account-based focus supports progression
4. Opportunity→ Closed-Won	15-25%	20-25%	**At Risk**– Governance-driven procurement friction
5. End-to-End Sales Cycle	3-6 months	~4 months	**Aligned** — Within SaaS norms

SOURCE:

1. https://openviewpartners.com/blog/saas-sales-metrics-conversion-benchmarks/
2. https://blog.hubspot.com/sales/sales-qualified-lead ;
3. https://www.saastr.com/what-is-a-good-demo-conversion-rate-for-saas-startup/

A focused 25% engagement strategy can generate ~$600k in ARR under benchmark conversion assumptions.

Assumptions

- Qualified institution: 292
- **Annual Contract Value (ACV):** $40,000
- Win rate applied at Opportunity → Closed-Won stage

Scenario-Based ARR Projection Using Benchmark Conversion Rates

Scenario	%of Engaged	Engaged Accounts	Win Rate	Expected Wins	Annual Contract Value	New ARR
Low	~17%	50	15%	~8	$40,000	~$320k
Base (Recommended Target)	**~25%**	**75**	**20%**	**15**	**$40,000**	**~$600k**
High	~34%	100	25%	25	$40,000	~$1.0M

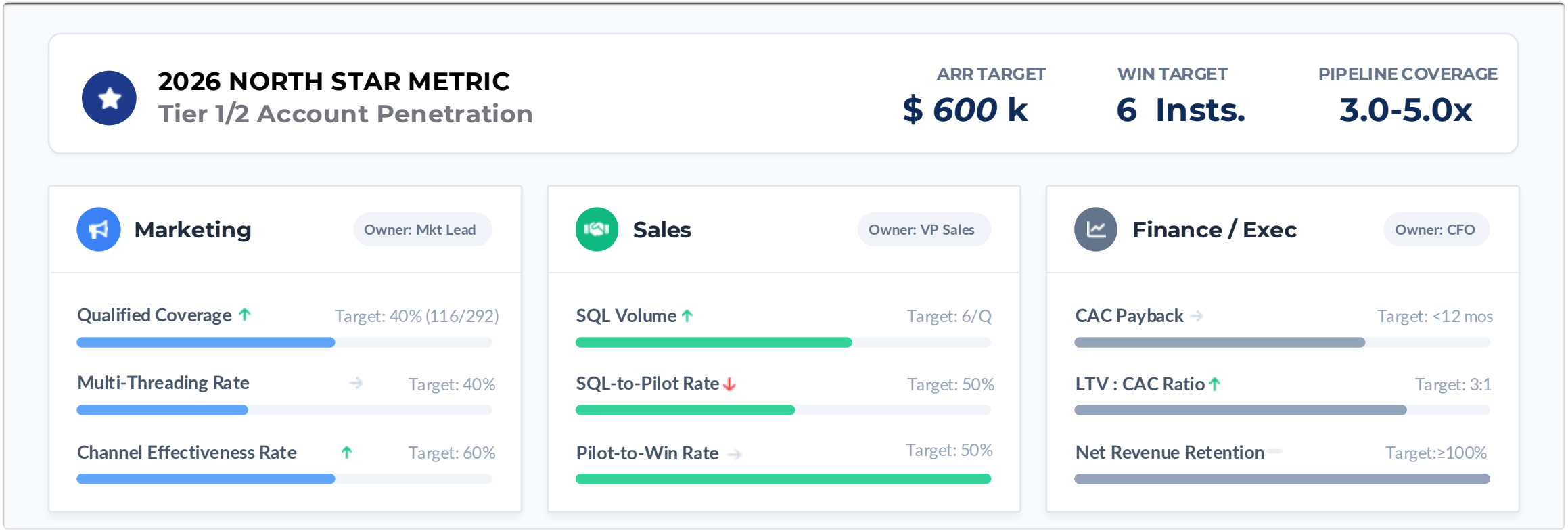
- *Revenue potential scales with disciplined conversion performance rather than full-market coverage.*

SOURCE: https://pathmonk.com/conversion-rate-benchmark-industry/

KPI Framework & Tracking Model

Clear KPIs and ownership enable VEGA to track progress and iterate

Dashboard



SOURCE: https://www.netsuite.com/portal/resource/articles/erp/saas-metrics.shtml

Selected work sample excerpt - Cygnus VEGA

From Awareness to Acceleration: VEGA's 180-Day Event Strategy

Phase 1: Awareness
0–60 Days

- **NACAC National College Fair – Cleveland**
  - Cleveland, Ohio
  - Feb 22, 2026
- **OLC Innovate 2026**
  - Virtual
  - Mar 3–5, 2026
- **NERCOMP Annual Conference**
  - Providence, Rhode Island
  - Mar 9–11, 2026

Phase 2: Positioning
60–120 Days

- **UPCEA Annual Conference 2026**
  - New Orleans, Louisiana
  - Apr 15–17, 2026
- **EDUCAUSE Summit | Developing an AI-Ready Workforce**
  - Virtual
  - May 13, 2026

Phase 3: Acceleration
120–180 Days

- **eduWeb Summit 2026**
  - Orlando, Florida
  - Jul 14–16, 2026
- **UPCEA SOLAR Conference 2026**
  - Boston, Massachusetts
  - Jul 29–31, 2026

Strategic Objectives by Phase

0–60 Days Results

- Generated qualified interest at 11+ conferences
- Established multi-threaded connections with key accounts
- Identified high-priority accounts for structured follow-up

60–120 Days Results

- Moved discussions from tactical to strategic planning
- Secured inclusion in broader martech and AI initiatives
- Aligned messaging with institutional governance priorities

120–180 Days Results

- Advanced late-stage opportunities toward close
- Secured formal evaluations and multi-stakeholder engagement
- Developed pilot programs and proposal documentation

SOURCE: https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1JI3SGMbUuY98Kqu6sfkSftE1OfYUHq0g/edit?gid=1406678576#gid=1406678576

Selected work sample excerpt - Cygnus VEGA

DUKE FUQUA SCHOOL OF BUSINESS

A Disciplined Growth Strategy to Win, De-Risk, and Scale VEGA

A strategic roadmap to drive sustainable growth at institutional clients through disciplined account targeting, risk mitigation, and systematic value expansion.

1

FOCUS:
Win the Right Accounts

- Deploy a revenue-weighted ICP with explicit thresholds for digital maturity and operational complexity
- Reallocate 75% of quota-carrying reps to Tier 1–2 targets
- Shift KPIs from top-line revenue to weighted ACV, expansion rate, and time-to-value

2

PROTECT:
De-Risk the Sales Motion

- Lead discovery with compliance, governance, and security—not reporting features
- Engage IT and security stakeholders by qualification stage
- Pilot ICP definition quarterly with win/loss analysis to prevent misalignment

3

EXPAND:
Scale Institutional Value

- Position VEGA as a system-wide operating standard across campuses and departments
- Use compliance-first positioning as a differentiated entry point
- Deploy structured post-sale expansion playbook targeting 3+ programs in Year 1

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